

Five Focus Areas for the Next Five Years

What India needs to do to realise its full potential in the next five years



WHAT IMAGERY of India would someone looking at it from afar in 1947 have conjured

up for life in the country 77 years later? On many dimensions, much of what has been achieved would have appeared unrealistic, if not outright delusory. That India survives as a working democracy, is the fifth-largest economy in the world, and has landed a spaceship on the south side of the moon would have seemed fanciful. That life expectancy had doubled to 70 years from the 32 years it was in 1947 would seem unbelievable. In fact, even drawing a Test match against England would have seemed like a dream and a movie like *Gully Boy* might have been listed under the fiction category about future Indian society on Netflix (if the platform had existed). We escaped becoming a Myanmar, Afghanistan, or Pakistan and today is the cynosure of the world with both business and political leaders having to incorporate India in their strategic calculus. So, I wish by 2029 Indians living in what I have called (I have described India as three nations of—50 million Europeans, 425 million Indonesians and nearly a billion who are still living in sub-Saharan Africa) sub-Saharan Africa, start visualising the possibility of a better life for themselves in



BY JANMEJAYA SINHA

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their lifetime.

My top five focus areas for the next five years in India would be:

1. Fixing water: Conserving water needs to be a national mission. The Jal Jeevan Mission is providing access to water, but we need an equal push in conserving water. Our water policy reforms need to be acted upon even though they are hard and politically difficult. I have argued before about pricing water and power correctly for agriculture, so that rice and sugarcane are only grown in areas suitable for them. We need to create adequate incentives for farmers to shift away from rice in water-starved areas. We need to protect effluent discharge into our rivers by both investing in sewage treatment plants and increasing penalties for companies that violate guidelines. We should have peak load pricing for water and pricing should also increase with higher usage. We should also have constant monitoring of river water purity and water table levels on a national grid put up and displayed outside Parliament and outside every state legislature. Finally, we need all cities to take up water conservation seriously—rainwater harvesting, installing water-efficient devices in government buildings and public toilets, repairing old pipes and leaks, and city planning should take special care of all water bodies.